



Congrats, Semifinalists! Reference the list below as you prepare for Pitch Day on Nov. 21!

Semifinals Prep Checklist (all items are required)

- ☐ Confirm your participation within 24 hours & share individual headshots – **Due EOD Thursday, Nov. 6**
- ☐ RSVP and attend the [Semifinalist Orientation & Pitch Workshop](#) – **Due Wednesday, Nov. 12**
- ☐ Book a Coaching Session with a Mentor during the weeks of November 10 & 17 – **Due Thursday Nov. 20**
- ☐ Create a poster for the Semifinalist Showcase (Pick up at Semifinalist Orientation and Pitch Workshop on Nov. 12 OR in create[space] between Nov. 13 & Nov. 21) – **Due Friday, Nov. 21**
- ☐ Prepare your 10-minute presentation & 30-second elevator pitch for pitch day – **Friday, Nov. 21**

Judging Overview

Judges review concepts on the strength of the ideas presented with the knowledge that the Fowler Business Concept Challenge (FBCC) is an “entry-level” competition for students of all majors and class levels. In addition to the criteria in the rubric, your pitch should highlight following areas:

- A solid understanding of the benefits of your products or service and the value proposition
- Defensible estimate of the potential market and the business potential revenues
- A business revenue model
- Good grasp of the existing competition and a solid explanation of your unique value proposition
- Solid explanation of why your idea is feasible and how you would begin to execute it with some mentoring and assistance

Semifinals Pitch Format

Teams can use PowerPoint, video clips, pictures and props at their discretion. You will pitch live to a panel of judges. Your pitch block will include:

- 10-minute pitch
- 13-minute Q&A
- 2-minute transition time to the next team

Each team is limited to a maximum of **20 slides** in their presentation. You can use less than the full 10 minutes without incurring any penalty. Regardless of your pitch length, aim to use your allotted time to present your concept in the best light possible, keeping it crisp, focused and to the point.

Elevator / 30-second pitch

All semifinalist teams will share a 30-second pitch of their concept with the audience during the lunch program on competition day. Additional tips and guidelines for your fast pitch are included in this packet.

If you advance to the Finals

- You or your team deliver your 10-minute pitch again to a new panel of judges the afternoon of Friday, November 21.
- All Finalists must be available between 11:30 a.m. - 4:45 p.m.
- **The Awards Ceremony will be held from 4:00-4:45 p.m.**, immediately following the final pitch competition. A reception with light refreshments will follow shortly after.

If you don't advance to the Finals

- If you did not create your poster for the Semifinalists showcase ahead of time, you can use afternoon pitch time (1:00-2:45 p.m.) to create your poster in create[space]
- If you created your poster ahead of time, stick around to watch the finalist pitches or if you need to leave, be back and ready for the Semifinalist Showcase by 2:45 p.m. on the 2nd Floor of ASC

Semifinalist Orientation & Pitch Coaching Workshop – Nov.12

We will cover:

- Day of competition prep – everything you need to know before your pitch.
- Tips and tricks for creating a winning pitch and compelling presentation deck.
- Practice your 30-second elevator pitch.

Day-of-Competition Reminders: Nov. 21

- Dress professionally.
- Have your pitch deck available on a flash drive. Flash drives will be distributed on Nov. 12 during the Semifinalists Orientation and Pitch Prep event and available for pickup at the front desk, McNeely 128, after Nov. 12 if you are unable to attend in person. You may also use your own flash drive.
- Watch your pace so that judges can understand you. We will be firm on the 10-minute pitch time limit.

2025 Fowler Business Concept Challenge		
Friday, Nov. 21, 2025		
Time	Activity	Location
7:45 a.m.	Student Check-In & Flash Drive Drop-off <i>Continental Breakfast</i>	<i>ASC Woulfe Atrium</i>
8:00 a.m.	Judge Check-In <i>Continental Breakfast</i>	<i>ASC Woulfe Atrium</i>
8:30 a.m.	Welcome <i>(Danielle Campeau, Laura Dunham)</i>	<i>ASC Woulfe Hall</i>
8:50 a.m.	Student Orientation	<i>ASC - Dance Hall (Lower Level)</i>
9:10 a.m.	Semifinalist Presentations --Business & Social Tracks --16 teams per track --Pitch Format: 10-min. pitch, 13-min. Q&A, 2-min transition time to next team --Pitch Times: 9:10, 9:35, 10:00, 10:25 a.m.	<i>ASC 2nd & 3rd Floor Rooms</i>
10:50 a.m.	Judge Break	<i>ASC 2nd & 3rd Floor Rooms</i>
11:00 a.m.	Judge Deliberation <i>(Finalists Selected, Winner shared with room host)</i>	<i>ASC 2nd & 3rd Floor Rooms</i>
11:30 a.m.	Lunch	<i>ASC Woulfe Hall</i>
12:15 p.m.	Lunch Program --Lunch Remarks (Danielle Campeau) --Elevator Pitches (All Semifinalist Teams) --Announcement of Finalists (Professor Jay Ebben)	<i>ASC Woulfe Hall</i>

2025 Fowler Business Concept Challenge		
Friday, Nov. 21, 2025		
Time	Activity	Location
1:00 p.m.	Finals Judge Orientation	ASC 341
1:15 p.m.	Finals Presentations --Four finalists per track --Pitch Format: 10-min. pitch, 16-min. Q&A, 2-min transition to next team --Pitch Times: 1:15, 1:43, 2:11, 2:39 p.m.	South Woulfe - Social Track North Woulfe - Business Track
3:00 p.m.	Semifinalist Showcase Begins	ASC - 2nd Floor
3:15 p.m.	Judges Deliberate --Showcase and Reception run concurrently for students and guests	Business Track: ASC 341 Social Track: ASC 342
3:40 p.m.	Judges notify staff of winners	
4:00 p.m.	Awards Ceremony --Danielle Campeau, Billy Mzenga, Jessica Cooley, Rob Vischer, Ron Fowler to speak --Health Equity Champion Award announced --Best Use of Technology Award announced --Kate Herzog Award is announced --2nd Place Room Winners are announced --Finalist Teams announced in order	ASC Woulfe Hall
4:45 p.m.	Photos & Reception	ASC Woulfe Atrium
5:00 p.m.	Event Ends	

FOWLER BUSINESS CONCEPT CHALLENGE RUBRIC

Please evaluate the presentation on the following criteria:

(Rating System: 1 = very poor, 2 = poor, 3 = fair, 4 = good, 5 = excellent)

Business Track Criteria	Team 1	Team 2	Team 3	Team 4
Originality: business idea is new, novel and unique				
Value Proposition: a clear and compelling value proposition – legitimate, recognized need and appropriate solution				
Competitive Advantage: creates more value for customer than alternative solutions				
Market Opportunity: adequate market size; viable business model				
Feasibility: reasonable prospect of funding and successful implementation				
Stakeholders and Society: clear understanding and articulation of impact on stakeholders and society – demonstrate understanding of potential benefits, harms, ethical issues, that might arise in conjunction with this concept and how to address them				
Well-researched: demonstrates clear understanding of customer/customer need, market, competitive set, solution requirements				
Investment Opportunity: the business concept is attractive to potential investors as it has a good opportunity to have substantial return				
Presentation: effective materials and delivery				
Overall Score (to guide deliberations):				
Overall Rank (1 = highest, 4 = lowest)				



The Fowler Business Concept Challenge

Opus College of Business

UNIVERSITY OF
St. Thomas



**Semifinals Presentation &
30-Second Pitch
BUSINESS TRACK**

Semifinalist Deliverables



Each semifinalist team must prepare:

1. A **10-minute** (maximum) presentation and slide deck - to be presented live in front of judges on pitch day (Friday, November 21st)
2. A **30-second** pitch that one team member will share during the lunch program on pitch day (Friday, November 21st)



10-Minute Presentation and Slide Deck

Presentation Tips + Template



The following slides cover how to make a great 10-minute presentation of your business concept and provides a sample pitch deck. The sample is merely meant for guidance. Please add, delete, alter and customize this for your own purposes.

Key Elements of a Good Pitch



- Identify a real customer need
- Describe a solution that is **clear, understandable and meaningful** for some set of customers – articulate the value proposition to those customers
- Show your **advantage** over competitors
- Provide evidence of a large, growing market
- Explain how you will deliver the solution to your customer affordably and effectively, and how the venture will make money (revenue model)
- Tell us how it advances the common good
- Show why deal is good for the investor

First Slide: Company Name



Team Member Names

Opening Overview



Get the audience excited about your opportunity! Help them quickly understand the scale and impact of the problem you are solving and the value of your solution.

Some techniques for engaging them:

- **Link the topic to their experience:** *"How many of you have ever experienced this..." (make sure it is the kind of problem the audience has experienced and would love to have fixed)*
- **Paint a compelling picture with attention-getting statistics:** *"1 in 5 millennials suffers hearing loss. It can take less than 8 minutes of earbud use at high volumes for hearing to be damaged."*
- **Tell a story!** *Paint a picture of a particular person who is experiencing the problem you are solving, how it impacts them, and how you can transform their experience."*

Expand on Customer Need



- **Identify a real need** – an unsolved problem or a problem that could be solved in a better way
- **Specify who needs your help** – Who is the customer? How do they experience the problem and how does it impact their lives? What solutions have they tried and what are the shortcomings of those solutions?
- **Explain why customers will pay for a solution**



Describe Your Solution

Provide a mockup of the product or service.

For example,

- If it is an app, provide screen shots.
- If it is hardware, provide an illustrative representation.
- If it is a process or service, outline or diagram the process/service.

Offer a Value Proposition



- **Explain how and why your solution solves the customer's problem**
- **Describe the specific benefits** (example benefits below):
 - Does it generate more revenue for customers?
 - Does it cut customer time, effort or costs?
 - Does it increase customer efficiency, physical or emotional well-being, social connection, etc.?
 - Does is it allow customers to do something in a different and better way?
- **Show how it's better than alternatives**

Show Your Advantage Over Competitors



- Explain why your effort is distinctive
- Show why it's not easy for competitors to enter
- Explain why customers can't switch suppliers easily
- Reference your competitive advantage (patents, expertise, scale)

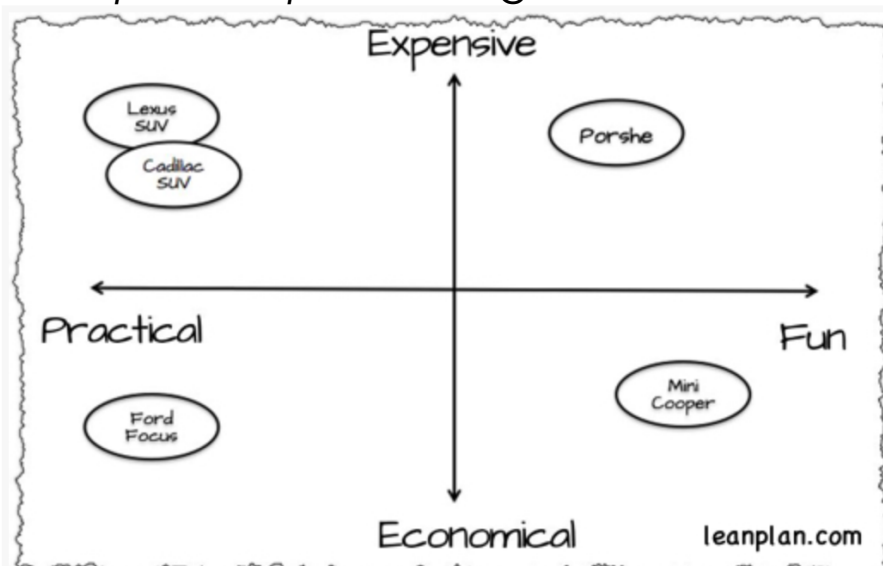
Summarize Competitive Landscape

Provide some form of competitive landscape analysis

Competitive feature analysis:

	My Offer	Competitor 1	Competitor 2	Competitor 3
Price	Low	High	High	High
Speed	Fast	Medium	Slow	Fast
Maintenance	None	Medium	High	Medium

Competitive positioning matrix:



Provide Evidence of a Market Opportunity



Provide evidence the market exists, is large, is growing

- How many people experience this problem/ fit your target description? How many people can you impact/ or the number of customers you can reasonably address?
- How much money is currently spent in this or related space? (in order to demonstrate that demand exists)
- Why is this a good time to launch this venture – are there any market/industry/technology trends that create a particularly compelling window of opportunity?

What is Your Business Model?

How will you **deliver this solution to your customer** affordably and effectively, and how will the **venture make money** (revenue model)?

- Who is going to pay for this? The end user? Someone who purchases for an end user? Another stakeholder (e.g. Love Your Melon)?
- How will they pay for this? (Fee for service? Subscription? Freemium? Licensing?)
- Provide enough explanation of how you will provide this product/service that your audience will see why it is feasible to do
- What are the largest costs and why do you feel these revenues will be able to cover them?

Why Should Someone Invest?



Why would this business be attractive to potential investors interested in a substantial financial return?

Team



(Member 1 Name)

(Member 1 Role on team)

(Member 1 Key facts that make them an asset)

(Member 2 Name)

(Member 2 Role on team)

(Member 2 Key facts that make them an asset)

Explain why you are the person/people to do this!

Why Should Judges Be Excited About Your Concept?



Provide a product positioning statement:

- To: [target customer], our [product] is the one [category] that [key benefit], unlike [nearest alternative].
- Example: *For consumers who want to purchase a wide range of products online with quick delivery, Amazon provides a one-stop online shopping site that sets itself apart from other online retailers with its customer obsession, passion for innovation, and commitment to operational excellence.*
- Remind them of any other facts – market trends, competitive advantage, etc. – that make this an exciting opportunity

Tip: Engage Your Audience



- Be relaxed and conversational but express conviction for your ideas
- Posture matters – stand straight, don't pace or fidget and make eye contact with your audience
- See yourself as telling a story
 - Pick words that create a visual image in listener's mind
 - Choose powerful words that grab attention
- Prepare ahead of time for questions they might ask, so you can stay relaxed and energized during Q&A

Tip: Keep Slides Simple, Visual and Clean



- One idea per slide
- Aim to use visuals more than words
 - Use charts and graphs to convey quantitative information
 - Use simple visuals/photos and minimal for qualitative information that can't be graphed.
- Check out [this link](#) for examples of great pitch decks (**ctrl + click "this link"**)

Example: Early AirBnB Pitch Deck

Welcome 1

AirBed&Breakfast

Book rooms with locals, rather than hotels.

This is a PowerPoint reproduction of an early AirBnB pitch deck via Business Insider @ <http://www.businessinsider.com/airbnb-a-13-billion-dollar-startups-first-ever-pitch-deck-2011-9>

Problem 2

Price is an important concern for customers booking travel online.

Hotels leave you disconnected from the city and its culture.

No easy way exists to book a room with a local or become a host.

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Solution 3

A web platform where users can rent out their space to host travelers to:

SAVE MONEY
when traveling

MAKE MONEY
when hosting

SHARE CULTURE
local connection to the city

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Market Validation 4

630,000
on temporary housing site
couchsurfing.com

17,000
temporary housing listings on SF
& NYC Craigslist from 07/09 – 07/16

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Market Size 5

1.9 Billion+
TRIPS BOOKED (WORDLWIDE)
Total Available Market

532M
BUDGET & ONLINE TRIPS
Serviceable Available Market

10.6M
TRIPS W/AB&B
Market Share

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Product 6

SEARCH BY CITY → REVIEW LISTINGS → BOOK IT!

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Business Model 7

We take a 10% commission on each transaction.

10.6M
TRIPS W/AB&B
Share of Market

\$20
AVG FEE
\$70/night @ 3 nights

\$200M
REVENUE
2008-2011

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Competition 9

OFFLINE TRANSACTION ← → ONLINE TRANSACTION

EXPENSIVE ← → AFFORDABLE

AirBed&Breakfast

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com

Competitive Advantages 10

1st TO MARKET
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

HOST INCENTIVE
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

LIST ONCE
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

EASE OF USE
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

PROFILES
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

DESIGN & BRAND
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Integer nec odio. Praesent libero.

Template by PitchDeckCoach.com



30-Second Pitch

Setting Up Your Pitch



- Your goal is to be clear, succinct and compelling!
- One team member, standing and dressed professionally, delivers the pitch
- Remember: 30 seconds max! A 30-second pitch can be practiced 20 times in 20 minutes so be sure to practice to the point where it is effortless!

The 30-Second Pitch



1. Start strong!
 - Grab them with a story, a question, a bold claim that relates to the need you are addressing or the solution you are providing
2. Keep it simple and clear
 - Don't bog down in details. Stick with crisp summaries
 - Here is the problem and why it is important
 - Here is our solution and why it meets the needs of our customers better than anything else out there
 - Here is how we are going to make it happen profitably
3. Close strong!
 - What's the most important thing you want your audience to remember? What is a memorable, creative way to accomplish that?